

AGES 40+

WEEK ONE

A FREE 5-DAY PROGRAM

THE *First* FIVE DAYS

A 5-day off-ice training program for hockey players **40 and up**.

Bodyweight-led. No gym required. Built on what the research actually says about training the aging athlete — joint health, tendon resilience, Zone 2 aerobic work, and power that doesn't punish you the next day.

01 MOBILITY

02 TENDONS

03 ZONE 2

04 POWER

05 INTEGRATION

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FOR THE 40+ HOCKEY PLAYER

TRAIN YOUR AGE. TRAIN *smart.*

You don't have less to gain from training after 40 — you have *different* things to gain. The research on the aging athlete is clear: tendon stiffness, joint quality, mitochondrial function, and rate of force development (RFD — how fast you can produce force) all decline with age. Every one of them is still highly trainable when you train them the right way.

Most programs written for "fitness over 40" miss this. They either treat you like you're fragile (you're not) or they ignore what your body actually does best now: recover slower, but adapt deeper. This program does neither.

The priority order through these five days is backed by the literature: **tissue quality first, then mobility, then power, then strength, then conditioning**. Slow eccentrics build tendon resilience. Zone 2 cardio outbuilds HIIT for the aerobic base. Power is maintained with low volume and high quality — not punished with high volume and fatigue.

After 40, the goal isn't to train harder than you did at 25 — it's to train smarter than you ever have.

01

TISSUE FIRST

Tendons and joints take longer to adapt than muscle. We train them deliberately — slow eccentrics, sustained isometrics, heavy slow resistance principles drawn straight from elite rehab and prehab protocols.

02

POWER, MAINTAINED

RFD declines with age, but it doesn't have to crash. Low-volume, high-quality plyometric and ballistic work — done well, done often — keeps the first step explosive and the shot heavy.

03

ZONE 2 OVER HIIT

A bigger aerobic base means faster between-shift recovery and a heart that doesn't have to work as hard. We build it the way the mitochondrial science says to build it — slow, steady, often.

YOUR FIVE-DAY ARC

FIVE DAYS. ONE WEEK. ONE *better* PLAYER.

Pick five days that work for you — they don't have to be Monday through Friday. Place Day 3 (Zone 2) on a day you have more time. Leave at least one full rest day in the middle. Each session runs 30 to 45 minutes including warm-up and cool-down. You need a small open space and a floor. A loaded backpack helps on Day 2. No other equipment.

If something doesn't feel right — sharp pain, joint pain, anything that lingers — stop. You've earned the right to be smart about this. Modify or skip and come back stronger.

THE WEEK AT A GLANCE

DAY 01	DAY 02	DAY 03	DAY 04	DAY 05
01	02	03	04	05
MOVEMENT QUALITY & MOBILITY	TENDON RESILIENCE & STRENGTH	AEROBIC BASE ZONE 2	POWER MAINTENANCE	HOCKEY INTEGRATION & RECOVERY
~ 40 MIN	~ 40 MIN	~ 35–45 MIN	~ 30 MIN	~ 40 MIN

HOW TO READ A WORKOUT

EVERY EXERCISE CARD HAS FIVE PARTS.

The number is just the order. Sets & reps tell you how many. **Tempo** tells you the speed of the rep — a 4-2-1-0 tempo means 4 seconds lowering, 2 seconds pause at the bottom, 1 second up, 0 rest at the top. **Rest** is how long you wait before the next set. The **coaching cue** is the one thing your coach would say standing next to you. **What it builds** tells you the hockey reason for the work.

01 EXERCISE NAME *the movement*

3 × 8 sets × reps

TEMPO 4-2-1-0 speed of the rep

REST 90s before the next set

HOW TO DO IT — exact instructions.

"Coaching cue." — the one thing.

BUILDS — the hockey reason.

THE NON-NEGOTIABLE

THE *warm-up.*

Five minutes. Every session. Non-negotiable — especially now. The older the athlete, the more they need to wake the tissues up before asking them to perform. This sequence covers everything that matters for hockey: hips, T-spine, ankles, shoulders. Move with control. Breathe through your nose where you can.

01

90/90 HIP SWITCH

2 ROUNDS × 6 EACH SIDE • SLOW TEMPO

Sit on the floor. Front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent 90° to the side. Lean forward gently over the front shin and feel the hip open. Then — keeping both knees on the floor — rotate the hips to switch sides. Both knees should land at 90° in the new position.

“Move slowly. Let the hips open.”

BUILDS Hip internal and external rotation — the joint range skating quietly takes from you.

02

WORLD'S GREATEST STRETCH

2 ROUNDS × 3 EACH SIDE • CONTROLLED

From a push-up position, step your right foot up beside your right hand. Drop your right elbow toward the inside of your right foot. Then rotate and reach the same arm up to the ceiling, following with your eyes. Place the hand back down, step back, switch sides.

“Open chest. Open hips. Long spine.”

BUILDS Full-body mobility prep — hips, T-spine, and shoulders all in one movement.

03

CAT-COW + THREAD THE NEEDLE

2 ROUNDS × 8 CAT-COW + 3 EACH SIDE THREAD • SLOW

On hands and knees. *Cat-cow*: arch the back up toward the ceiling (cat), then drop the belly and lift the chest (cow). Eight slow reps. *Thread the needle*: reach right arm under and across your body, drop the shoulder to the floor, hold 3 seconds. Switch.

“Slow. Long exhale on every move.”

BUILDS Spine articulation and mid-back mobility — where most of the stiffness lives after 40.

01 MOVEMENT QUALITY & *mobility.*

~ 40 MIN • BODYWEIGHT ONLY

Day 1 is the most important day of the week. Everything else is built on top of it. Today is about restoring the joint range and movement patterns that life — sitting, driving, the same skating pattern over and over — has quietly taken from you. No load. No intensity. Pure quality.

BEGIN WITH The Warm-Up (Page 04). Always.

01 COSSACK SQUAT

3 × 6 EACH SIDE • TEMPO 3-1-1-0 • REST 60S

Stand wide — feet about twice shoulder-width, toes slightly out. Shift weight onto your right leg and bend that knee deep. Left leg stays straight, heel down, toes up. Push back to center and switch sides. Hold a small counterweight if balance is tough.

“Heel down on the straight leg. Don’t rush the switch.”

BUILDS Hip and adductor mobility under load — directly relevant to skating stance and crossover depth.

02 HALF-KNEELING T-SPINE ROTATION

3 × 8 EACH SIDE • SLOW • REST 45S

Kneel on one knee, the other foot flat in front (both knees at 90°). Place hands behind your head with elbows wide. Rotate your upper body slowly toward the front leg, then back. Hips stay perfectly still — only the spine moves.

“Rotate from the ribs. Hips locked.”

BUILDS Thoracic rotation — the range you need for a clean shoulder check and a powerful shot.

03 BIRD DOG WITH 3-SECOND HOLD

3 × 6 EACH SIDE • REST 45S

On hands and knees. Slowly extend your right arm forward and left leg back — perfectly horizontal, head to heel. Hold three seconds. Hips don’t tip or twist — imagine a glass of water on your lower back. Switch sides.

“Long line, head to heel. Don’t tip the hips.”

BUILDS Anti-rotation core control — the spinal stability that protects your back during every twist on the ice.

04 SLOW REVERSE LUNGE

3 × 6 EACH LEG • TEMPO 3-1-1-0 • REST 60S

Stand tall. Step one foot back and slowly lower the back knee toward the floor over three seconds. Stop just before the knee touches. Drive through the front heel to stand up. The slow descent is the whole point.

“Slow on the way down. Smooth on the way up.”

BUILDS Single-leg strength, knee control, balance — three things that quietly fade after 40 if you don’t train them.

05 WALL SLIDE + REACH

3 × 10 • SLOW • REST 45S

Back, head, and arms pressed against a wall. Elbows bent at 90°, backs of hands touching the wall at ear level. Slowly slide your arms up overhead, keeping every point of contact the whole way. Slide back down.

“Wrists pinned to the wall. Don’t fake it with the lower back.”

BUILDS Shoulder mobility and upper-back posture — the antidote to a desk job and a hockey stance.

COOL-DOWN — 3 MIN Knees to chest, rock side to side 60s. Box breathing — in 4, hold 4, out 6 — for two minutes. Long exhales win.

02

TENDON RESILIENCE & *strength.*

~ 40 MIN • BACKPACK (5–15 KG)

Tendons adapt slower than muscle. They respond best to slow loading — long time under tension, controlled eccentrics, sustained isometrics. This is the **heavy slow resistance** principle, drawn straight from the orthopedic and sport science literature. Today the *tempos* matter more than the reps. Honor them.

YOU'LL NEED A loaded backpack (books, water bottles — 5–15 kg).

01

TEMPO GOBLET SQUAT

3 × 8 • TEMPO 4-2-1-0 • REST 90S

Hold a loaded backpack against your chest. Feet shoulder-width. Squat down over four full seconds. Pause two seconds at the bottom. Drive up in one. No rest at the top — straight into the next rep.

“Don't cheat the eccentric. The slow descent is the work.”

BUILDS Quad and patellar tendon adaptation via slow controlled loading — the protocol that keeps knees pain-free long-term.

02

SPANISH SQUAT — ISOMETRIC HOLD

3 × 30S HOLD • REST 60S

Loop a belt or strap around a sturdy pole at knee height, then around the back of your knees. Lean back until it's taut, squat to a 60° knee bend, and hold. The strap takes shear off the knee and loads the quad and patellar tendon directly.

“Sit back into the strap. Knees don't slide forward.”

BUILDS Patellar tendon resilience — the most-researched isometric protocol for chronic knee pain in the literature.

03

SINGLE-LEG ROMANIAN DEADLIFT

3 × 8 EACH SIDE • TEMPO 3-1-1-0 • REST 60S

Stand on one leg, slight bend in the knee. Hinge at the hip — lower your chest as the back leg extends behind you. Back leg and torso form one long line. Lower until you feel a hamstring stretch, then return.

“Longline — head, hips, heel.”

BUILDS Hamstring tendon resilience and posterior chain strength. Critical for protecting the lower back and powering the skating stride.

04

TEMPO PUSH-UP

3 × 6 • TEMPO 4-1-2-0 • REST 60S

Push-up position (knees down is fine — quality over ego). Lower over four seconds. Pause one inch off the floor for one second. Press up over two. Body in a straight line — no sagging hips.

“Squeeze the floor away on the way up.”

BUILDS Shoulder and elbow tendon resilience. Slow eccentrics protect joints that take a beating every season.

05

TIBIALIS RAISE

2 × 15 • TEMPO 2-1-2-0 • REST 45S

Stand with heels 15 cm from a wall, lean lightly back against it. Heels stay on the floor. Lift your toes up toward your shins as high as possible. Lower slowly. Burn down the front of the shin.

“Toes high. Slow on the way back down.”

BUILDS Anterior tibialis strength — prevents shin splints, improves balance, protects the ankle in cuts.

COOL-DOWN — 3 MIN Lying hamstring stretch, 60s each side. Box breathing — in 4, hold 4, out 4, hold 4 — four cycles.

03

AEROBIC BASE.

zone 2.

~ 35-45 MIN • CONTINUOUS LOW
INTENSITY

This is the day that does the most for your hockey, your recovery, and your life — and the day almost every adult athlete underdoes. Zone 2 is conversational-pace cardio. Slow enough that you can talk in full sentences, fast enough that you'd rather not.

The science is settled: low-intensity, long-duration aerobic work builds **mitochondrial density** — the cellular machinery that produces energy and clears fatigue. Mitochondrial function declines with age, but unlike most age-related declines, this one *reverses* with the right training stimulus.

A bigger aerobic base means faster between-shift recovery, a lower resting heart rate, and a body that's harder to fatigue. This is the day that pays back the hardest.

DURATION

30-45 *minutes*

Continuous. Same intensity start to finish. The first 10 minutes will feel almost too easy — that's correct. Stay there.

INTENSITY

180 *minus* AGE

Heart rate ceiling. A 45-year-old caps at 135 bpm. No monitor? Use the *talk test*: you should hold a full conversation with mild effort.

MODE — PICK ONE

WALK · *Bike* · JOG · SWIM · ROW

Brisk walk on an incline. Easy bike (stationary or road). Easy jog. Swim. Rowing machine. Pick what your joints prefer.

THE RULE

IF YOU CAN'T TALK, *too hard*.

If you can sing, too easy. The benefit is in the volume of low-intensity work, not the intensity itself. This is the opposite of every HIIT video — and exactly what your body responds to best now.

"The first ten minutes will feel almost too easy. THAT'S CORRECT. Stay there. The benefit is in the volume."

POST-SESSION — 5 MIN Slow walking cool-down, 3 minutes. Standing hamstring stretch, 30 seconds each side. Calf stretch against a wall, 30 seconds each side. Done.

04

POWER

maintenance.

~ 30 MIN • HIGH QUALITY, LOW VOLUME

Power — the ability to produce force quickly — is the most age-sensitive quality in sport. Rate of Force Development (RFD) declines faster than maximum strength. But it doesn't have to crash. The fix isn't more volume. It's **high-quality power work, done often, with full recovery between reps**. Every rep should look identical to the first.

THE RULE TODAY Full rest between sets. Stop the moment quality drops. This is the opposite of training to fatigue.

01

LOW POGO HOPS

3 × 8 • QUICK CONTACTS • REST 90S

Stand tall. Bounce on the balls of your feet, legs nearly straight. The bounce comes from your ankles and calves, not your knees. Low amplitude. Quick, light, quiet floor contacts. Like skipping rope without the rope.

"Quick feet. Floor is hot."

BUILDS Ankle stiffness and reactive strength — the elastic quality that gives you a first step.

02

BOX STEP-UP DRIVE

3 × 4 EACH LEG • FULL REST • REST 90S

A sturdy bench or step at about knee height. Place one foot on the step. Drive up explosively, bringing the opposite knee up to hip height as you stand. Land softly back down. Reset fully. The drive is the point — not the height.

"Punch the knee up. Fast."

BUILDS Concentric leg power — the exact pattern of pushing off the back leg during a stride.

03

LATERAL BOUND — STICK IT

3 × 3 EACH SIDE • FULL REST • REST 90S

Stand on one leg. Push off sideways and land on the other leg only. Hold that landing for two full seconds — perfectly balanced, knee bent, no wobble. The hold is non-negotiable. Then push back. That's two reps.

"Land. Freeze. Reset."

BUILDS The exact biomechanics of a skating push-off — plus the eccentric control to absorb the next stride.

04

ROTATIONAL THROW

3 × 5 EACH SIDE • REST 90S • MEDICINE BALL OR LOADED BAG

Stand sideways to a sturdy wall, about 2 m away. Hold a medicine ball (or a small loaded backpack with a handle) at hip height. Rotate hips and shoulders quickly, throwing the ball into the wall. Catch on the bounce. Reset between reps — there's no rush.

"Hips lead. Arms follow."

BUILDS Rotational power — the engine behind a hard shot and a quick body check.

05

PLYO PUSH-UP TO PAUSE

3 × 4 • FULL REST • HANDS ELEVATED OK

Push-up position — hands on a sturdy bench or low chair if needed. Lower fast. Push up explosively so the hands leave the surface briefly. Land softly. Pause two full seconds. Then the next rep. Full effort every single time.

"Push the floor away — hard."

BUILDS Upper-body power — for stick battles, board work, and explosive pushing.

COOL-DOWN — 3 MIN Walk 90 seconds. Calf stretch, 30s each side. Couch stretch (hip flexor), 30s each side. Done.

05

HOCKEY INTEGRATION & *recovery.*

~ 40 MIN • TWO BLOCKS

Day 5 is the integration session. You'll move through hockey-specific patterns in a circuit format that mimics the work-to-rest demands of the game. Then you'll spend the back half of the session on something most adult athletes skip entirely: **deliberate recovery**.

Both halves matter. Block A teaches your body to apply what you built this week. Block B is what lets you do it all again next week.

BLOCK A

HOCKEY PATTERN CIRCUIT

4 MOVEMENTS × 3 ROUNDS • REST 90S BETWEEN ROUNDS

- A1** **COSSACK SQUAT 4 EACH SIDE**
Wide stance, weight shift, deep on one side, heel down on the other. Slow.
- A2** **SINGLE-LEG RDL 5 EACH SIDE**
Controlled. Long line head to heel. Slight bend in the planted knee.
- A3** **PALLOF PRESS HOLD 20S EACH SIDE**
Anchor a band (or a rolled towel held tight by a partner) at chest height. Step sideways, hold both hands straight out from your sternum, resist the pull. Don't rotate.
- A4** **LATERAL BOUND — STICK 3 EACH SIDE**
Push off sideways. Land on one leg. Hold the landing two full seconds before the next rep.

BLOCK B

DELIBERATE RECOVERY

10 MINUTES TOTAL • DON'T SKIP THIS

- B1** **FOAM ROLL 4 MIN**
Or a massage ball on a hard surface. 30s each: quads, IT bands, glutes, mid-back. Pause on tight spots and breathe.
- B2** **COUCH STRETCH 90S EACH SIDE**
Back foot up on a couch or chair, front leg in a lunge. Squeeze the back glute hard. The stretch hits the hip flexor and quad.
- B3** **90/90 BREATHING 3 MIN**
Lie on your back, feet flat on a chair, knees and hips at 90°. Hands on your ribs. In slowly through the nose. Long exhale through the mouth. Re-set the diaphragm and downshift the nervous system.

FOR THE DAYS OFF

THE everyday FLOW.

A daily mobility sequence for the days you're not training. Ten minutes. The minimum effective dose to keep your joints feeling ten years younger. Do this in the morning, before bed, or any time you've been sitting too long. No equipment. No excuses.

01

CAT-COW

60 SECONDS

Hands and knees. Alternate arching and rounding the spine. Slow. Breathe with each rep — exhale on the round, inhale on the arch.

TARGETS Spinal articulation, lower back.

02

DOWN DOG → COBRA FLOW

60 SECONDS

From push-up position, push hips up and back to downward dog. Flow forward, drop the hips, chest up to cobra. Back and forth.

TARGETS Hamstrings, calves, hip flexors, T-spine.

03

90/90 HIP SWITCH

90 SECONDS

Sitting on the floor, both knees at 90°. Rotate hips to switch sides. Take your time. Lean forward over the front shin between switches.

TARGETS Hip internal and external rotation.

04

WORLD'S GREATEST STRETCH

90 SECONDS

3 each side. From a lunge, drop the elbow inside the front foot. Then rotate and reach up. Move slowly between sides.

TARGETS Hips, T-spine, shoulders — whole-body.

05

COUCH STRETCH

90S EACH SIDE

Back foot elevated on a couch or chair. Front leg in a tall lunge. Squeeze the back glute hard. Stay tall. Hold.

TARGETS Hip flexors, quads, anterior chain.

06

DEAD HANG

60 SECONDS

Pull-up bar: hang. Relax through the shoulders, let gravity decompress. No bar? Stand in a doorway, reach overhead, gently lean back into a passive stretch.

TARGETS Shoulders, lats, spine decompression.

Ten minutes a day, every day, will do more for your hockey at 45 than any workout you can name.

RECOVERY & LIFESTYLE

RECOVERY IS WHERE THE *adaptation* HAPPENS.

At 25, you could outwork bad recovery. At 40+, you can't — and you shouldn't want to. Recovery isn't a soft topic; it's the literal mechanism by which your body becomes stronger. Skip this page and the five training days give you a fraction of what they could. Get this right and everything else compounds.

SLEEP

7-9

HOURS PER NIGHT

Deep sleep is when growth hormone is released and tissue repair happens. After 40, the body produces less of it and you have to work harder to defend the sleep window. Cool room. Dark room. Screens off 60 minutes before bed. Consistent bedtime. This is the single highest-ROI thing on this page.

FUEL

30G

PROTEIN PER MEAL

A palm-sized portion of protein at every main meal — the research on protein needs for the 40+ athlete has shifted upward in the last decade. Fill the rest of the plate with vegetables and fruit (variety matters). Limit ultra-processed foods. No supplement will outperform real food in adequate quantities.

HYDRATION

2.5-3.5L

WATER PER DAY

The thirst signal weakens with age — meaning you're often more dehydrated than you feel. Start the day with a glass of water before coffee. Keep a bottle visible. Pale-yellow urine is the target. Even mild dehydration drops power output by 5-10%. Worth fixing.

You can't out-train bad sleep, bad food, and bad hydration. Especially now.

MORE IS ON THE WAY

THIS IS JUST THE *beginning.*

The 12-week structured program is coming. The Elite Hockey Drills app is coming. Both are being built with the same method, the same care, and the same commitment to programming that respects the sport and the athlete — at every age. If these five days landed, what's coming next is built for you.

COMING SOON

THE 12-WEEK PROGRAM

A complete off-ice training system. Power, speed, strength, conditioning — periodized week by week. Built for hockey players who want a real program, not a generic template. Specific tracks for every age window, including the one you just trained.

COMING SOON

THE ELITE HOCKEY DRILLS APP

Drills, video demonstrations, programming, all in one place. Built from the ground up for hockey players — designed by a coach, not a software company. iOS and Android.

BE THE FIRST TO KNOW

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Follow on Instagram for weekly off-ice drills, coaching breakdowns, and the first word on when the program and the app drop.

[ELITEHOCKEYDRILLS.COM](https://elitehockeydrills.com)



EDU	M.ED. Sport Science
EXP	10+ years coaching
ROLES	Head Off-Ice Coach — UAE National Ice Hockey Team
TEACHES	PE & Sport Science
BRAND	Founder, Elite Hockey Drills

FROM THE COACH

COACH DAVID CIBOCH

M.ED. SPORT SCIENCE / STRENGTH & CONDITIONING / HOCKEY

I'm a sport science coach who has spent the last decade working with hockey players — from first-time skaters all the way up to international competition. I've worked with the UAE national ice hockey program and now work full-time as a Physical Education and Sport Science teacher.

I built Elite Hockey Drills because the off-ice training world is full of generic, copy-paste programs that don't respect the sport or the player — and even less of it speaks to the athlete still competing past 40. You're not "lucky to still be playing." You're an athlete who has earned the right to be programmed for.

If you put these five days in honestly, you've done real work. The 12-week program will go further. I'll see you there.

— *Coach David*

"The smartest athletes in any rink are the ones who figured out that training is a long game."

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